BUILDING THE FOUNDATION:

Turning Lived Experience into Measurable Impact



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NGU Fundraiser | Nov. 4, 2025

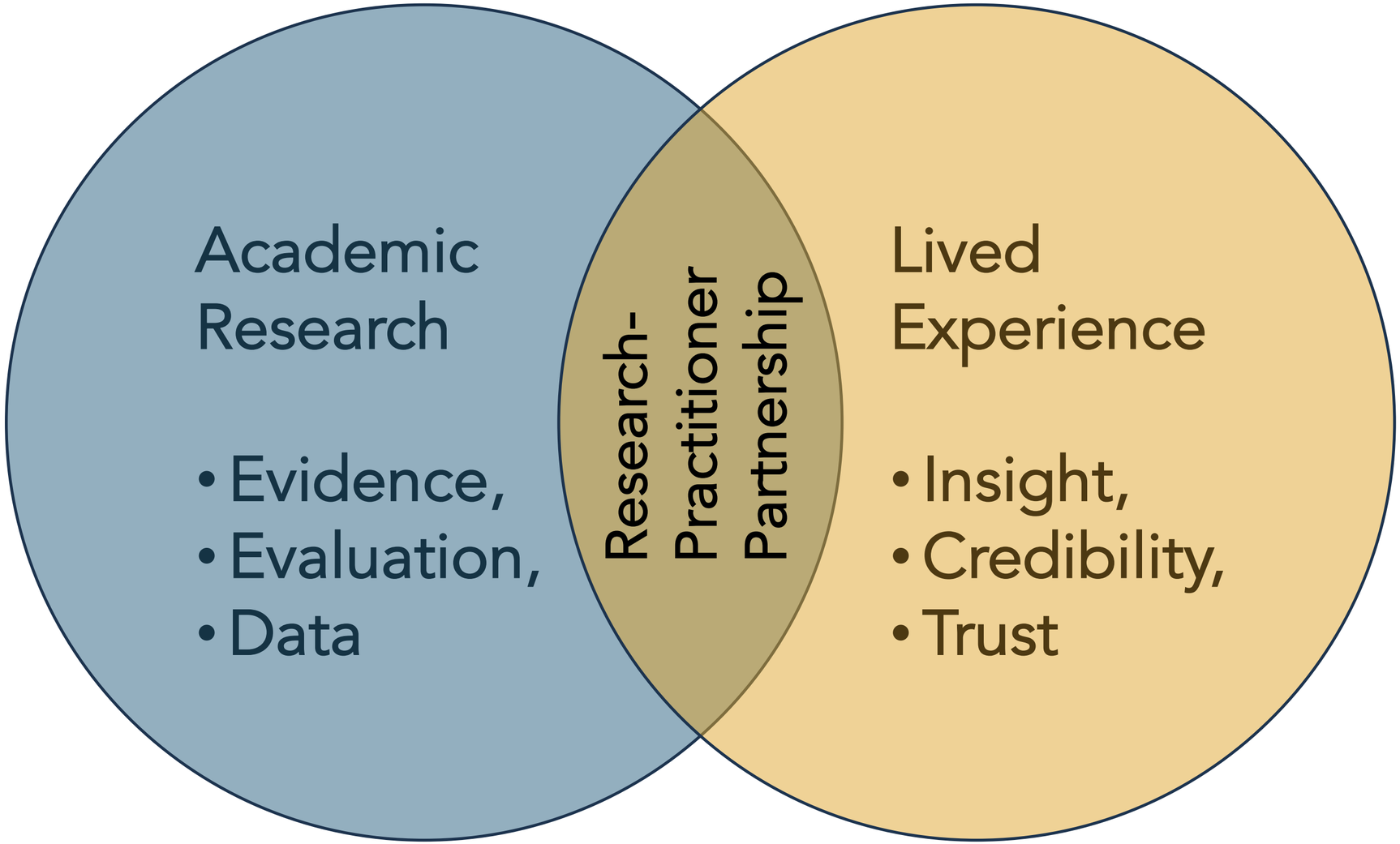
REENTRY HAPPENS EVERY DAY – BUT SUCCESS ISN'T GUARANTEED

- Each year, roughly 400,000 leave state and federal prisons
- Many *want* to succeed
- Success takes more than simply motivation

WHY REENTRY PROGRAMS STRUGGLE: Promise Without Infrastructure

- Dedicated leaders
- Life-changing missions
- BUT!! Limited structure, funding, and evaluation capacity

BRIDGING RESEARCH AND LIVED EXPERIENCE



NEVER GIVE UP TRANSITIONAL LIVING

NGU

TRANSITIONAL LIVING

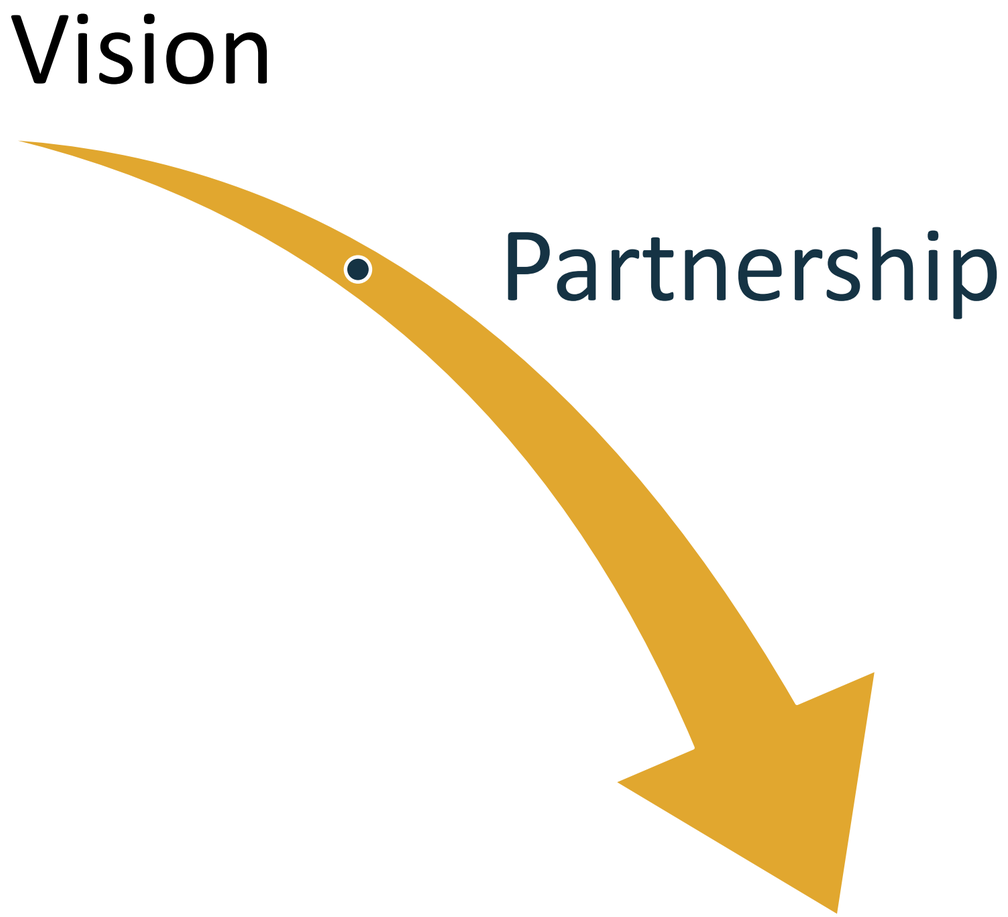
"NEVER GIVE UP"

BUILDING THE FOUNDATION

Vision



BUILDING THE FOUNDATION



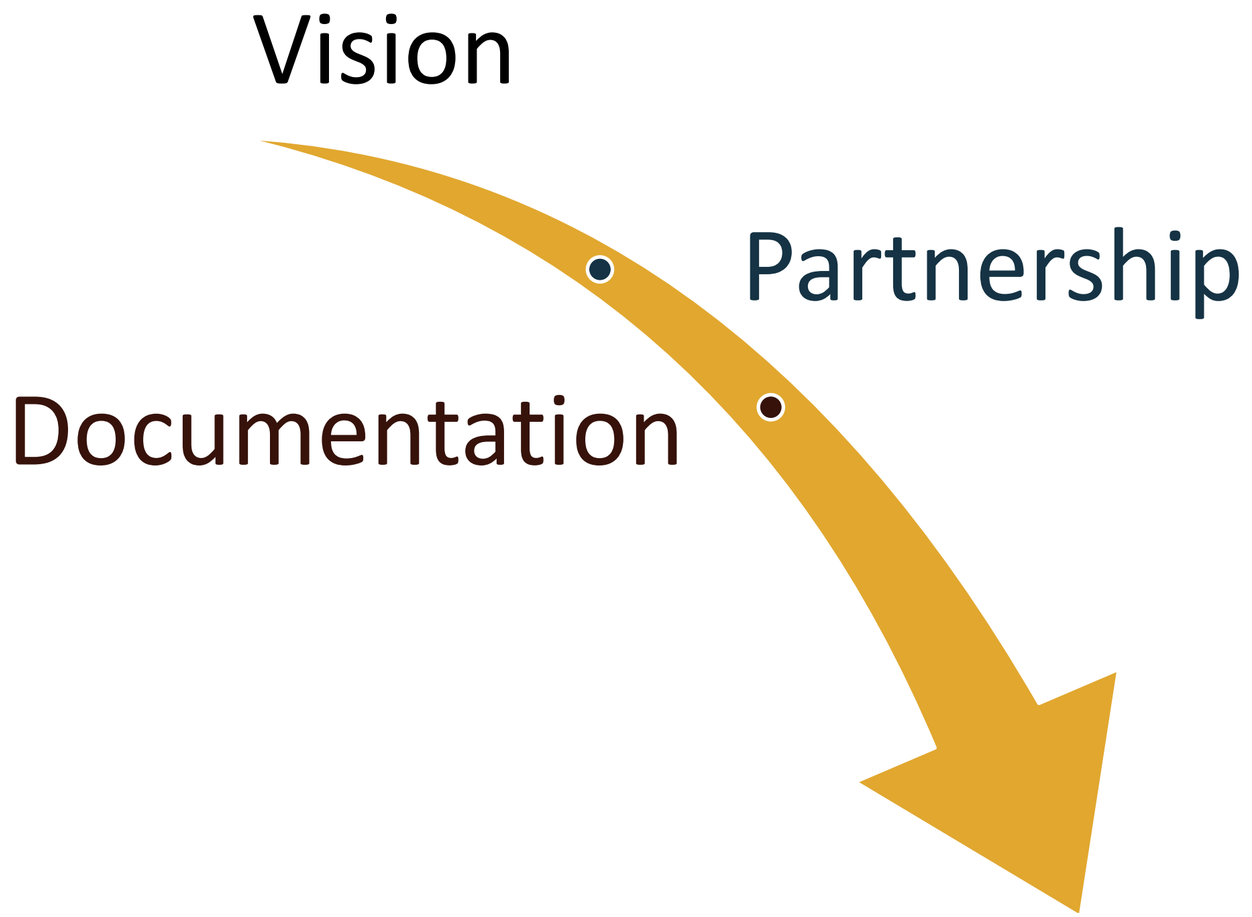
Never Give Up: Strengthening Reentry Through Research and Practice Collaboration

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Shane Reilly[2]

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Collaborating Across Differences in Sentencing and Corrections: Process and Outcomes
DCS Handbook on Corrections and Sentencing, Volume 11
Editors: Drs. Ebony Ruhland, Julie Baldwin, Jodi Lane, and Ashley Nellis

BUILDING THE FOUNDATION



Never Give Up Transitional Living Program Description

Updated: May 14, 2025

1. **Program Overview**
    a. Program Name: Never Give Up Transitional Living
    b. Organization: Good Turn Labor LLC
    c. Contact Person: Shane Reilly, MS
    d. Contact Phone and Email: 402.359.7404 / ngutlomaha@gmail.com

2. **Establishing the Problem: Situation Statement**

The average daily population of the Nebraska Department of Correctional Services (NDCS) is approximately 5,880 individuals, and roughly 2,000 people are released from Nebraska prisons each year. Nationally, over 95 percent of currently incarcerated individuals will be released at some point in the future. The reentry process presents serious challenges to the reintegration of formerly incarcerated persons in the community, with the most representative studies revealing that approximately 80% are rearrested within nine years, and slightly over half return to prison on a technical parole violation or with a new conviction within five years.

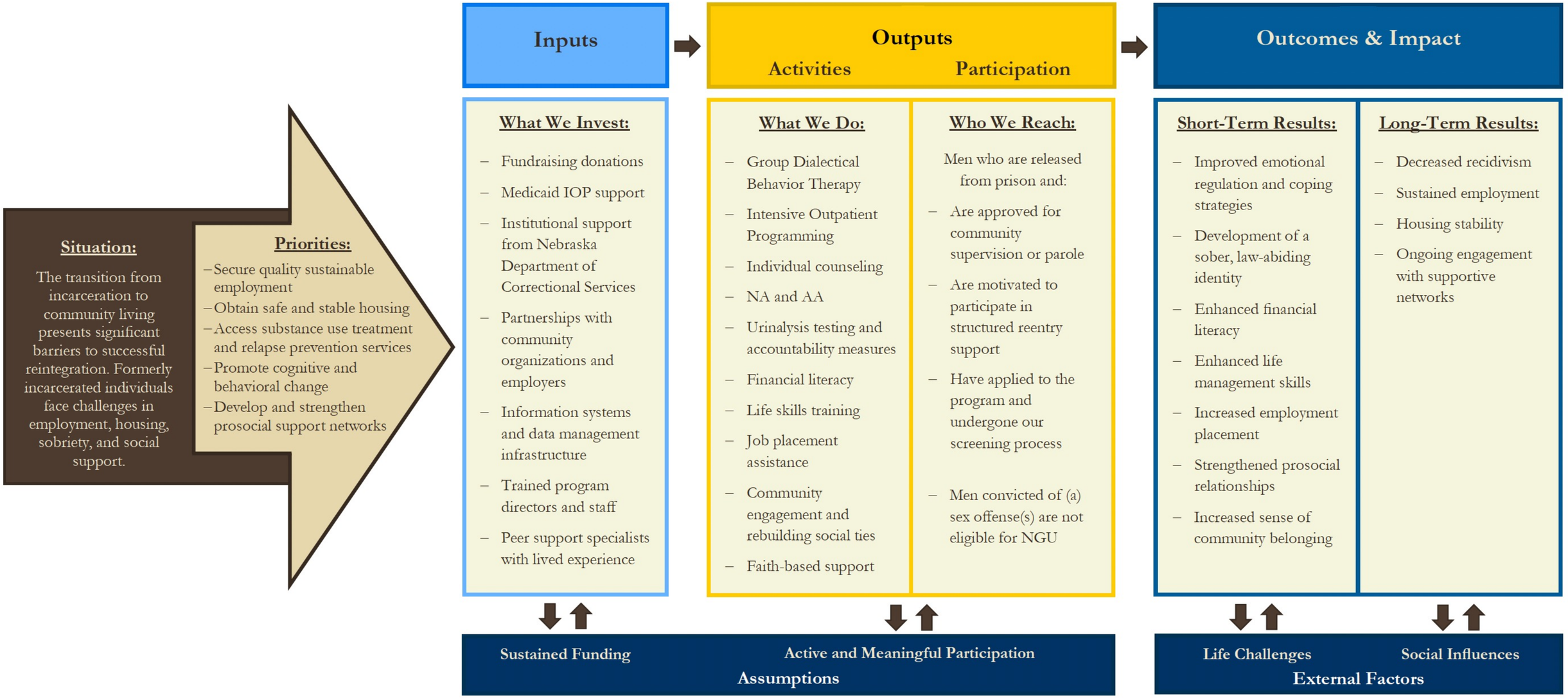
Critical to a successful reentry experience are obtaining quality employment, securing a prosocial place to live, developing a community support network, getting drug treatment (as needed), and changing one's identity and negative thinking patterns. However, many formerly incarcerated individuals have difficulties obtaining and maintaining these critical elements.

3. **Introduction**

The Never Give Up (NGU) Transitional Living Program is a structured transitional housing program operated under the nonprofit 501(c)(3) organization, Good Turn Labor, to support formerly incarcerated individuals as they reintegrate into the community. The program provides safe, stable housing alongside employment support, dialectical behavior therapy (DBT), Intensive Outpatient Programming (IOP) for mental health and substance use treatment, life skills training, social support, and more to reduce recidivism and improve long-term outcomes.

Designed to align with the priorities of the NDCS, Nebraska Board of Parole, and Nebraska Department of Parole Supervision services, NGU is a sober, transitional, peer-support intervention program that ensures returning citizens have the resources and structure necessary to successfully transition from incarceration to independent living.

Figure 1. Never Give Up Transitional Living program: Logical model for successful community reintegration



Note. Recidivism is defined as returning to prison within three years post-release

Abbreviations: IOP = Intensive Outpatient Program, NA = Narcotics Anonymous, AA = Alcoholics Anonymous, NGU = Never Give Up Transitional Living

Never Give Up Transitional Living

Program Application

Never Give Up (NGU) Transitional Living is a 12-week structured, sober transitional living program designed to support formerly incarcerated individuals as they reintegrate into the community. The program provides safe, stable housing alongside employment support, dialectical behavior therapy, life skills training, social support, and more to improve long-term outcomes. Additionally, NGU is staffed by a team of professionals with lived experiences—they have been incarcerated and since turned their lives around—who are committed to providing high-quality reentry and peer support services.

You may apply up to four months before your anticipated release date. Contact us if you need assistance filling out the application.

Individuals convicted of sex offenses or on the sex offender registry are not permitted to participate in NGU Transitional Living. *We encourage you to seek out alternative programs.*

To be accepted into NGU Transitional Living an applicant must complete this application, in full, and be interviewed by the program director. Carefully read the application and honestly answer the questions. *Living at NGU Transitional Living is special and if you understand its value, it can help you achieve comfortable sobriety without relapse.*

Print Name (First, Middle, Last): _____

Date of Birth: _____/_____/_____

What is your marital status? Never Married ☐ Married ☐ Separated/Divorced ☐ Other ☐

Do you have dependent children? Yes ☐ No ☐

- If Yes, how old are they? _____
- Do you have legal custody of your dependent children? Yes ☐ No ☐

Do you or will you receive welfare or other non-job-related income (i.e., disability)?

Yes ☐ No ☐

Never Give Up Transitional Living:

Phone Screening Interview Guide

Introduction:

Hello, my name is [interviewer's name], and I am reaching out on behalf of the Never Give Up Transitional Living program. This is an 84-day, structured, sober living program designed to support individuals like you as you transition back into the community after incarceration. What makes this program different is that it is entirely run by people who have been through it too—all of us, myself included, have done time. We understand the real challenges that come with reentry, and we are here to walk that path with you. Never Give Up is a "we" program—no one does this alone.

I have already reviewed your application, so today's conversation is a chance for us to talk more about your goals, your readiness for change, and how we can support you. There are no right or wrong answers here, just be honest and real. That's the one way this works.

Section 1: Substance Use

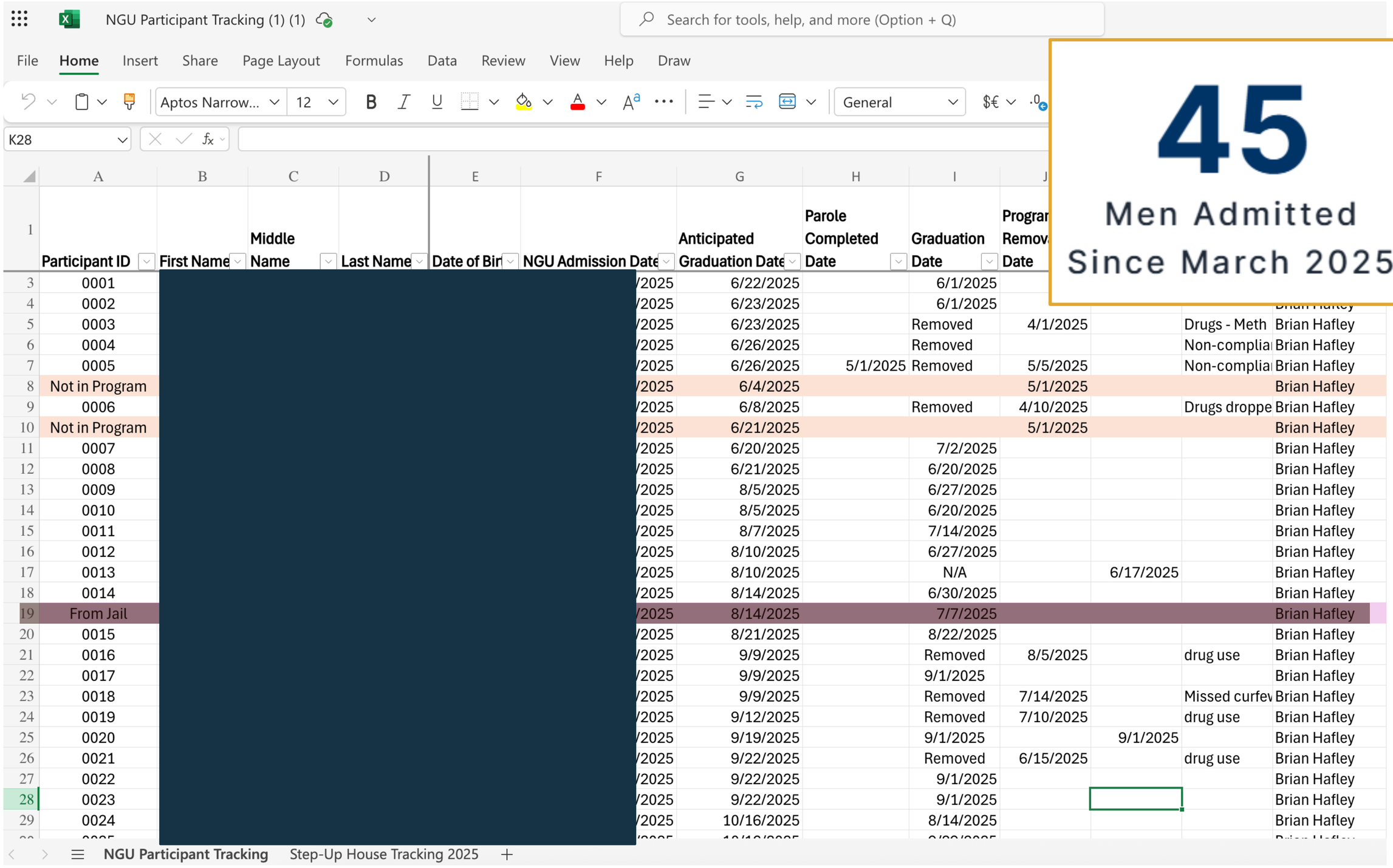
I want to start by talking about substance use. Never Give Up is a sober living program—that means no using, no selling, no substances in the house. We know from experience that staying clean is key to making real change. We're not here to judge, just to understand where you're at and if this program is the right fit.

1. Tell me a little bit about your history with drugs/alcohol.
    a. Do you believe drugs/alcohol have caused problems in your life?
    b. Have you ever tried to stop using/drinking before?
        i. What did that look like?
    c. Have you been to treatment or attended meetings?
        i. What worked and didn't work for you in previous programs or meetings?
2. What got you into prison?
3. What do you see as the biggest challenge you'll face in reentry?

Section 2: Commitment to Structure

I want to walk you through what day-to-day life looks like at Never Give Up. This program is about more than just staying out—it's about building a new routine and focusing on your recovery. That means waking up early, making your bed, staying clean, working, and being around others who are trying to change too.

1. While you are here you will attend IOP. Do you have a problem with that?
2. Tuesday, Wednesday, and Thursday, you will attend AA or NA. Do you have a problem with that?
3. On Sunday's we attend church. Do you have a problem with that?
4. You will also be expected to keep your space clean, participate in programming activities, follow the house rules and expectations, and work. We'll help you find a job, but the focus here is not just working—it's healing, staying sober, and staying free. This is about your life, are you committed to changing your lifestyle?


NGU Participant Tracking (1) (1)
Search for tools, help, and more (Option + Q)
File Home Insert Share Page Layout Formulas Data Review View Help Draw
Aptos Narrow... 12
General
K28
45
Men Admitted
Since March 2025
Participant ID First Name Middle Name Last Name Date of Bir NGU Admission Date Anticipated Graduation Date Parole Completed Date Graduation Date Progra Remov Date
0001 /2025 6/22/2025 6/1/2025
0002 /2025 6/23/2025 6/1/2025
0003 /2025 6/23/2025 Removed 4/1/2025 Drugs - Meth Brian Hafley
0004 /2025 6/26/2025 Removed Non-compli Brian Hafley
0005 /2025 6/26/2025 5/1/2025 Removed 5/5/2025 Non-compli Brian Hafley
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From Jail /2025 8/14/2025 7/7/2025 Brian Hafley
0015 /2025 8/21/2025 8/22/2025 Brian Hafley
0016 /2025 9/9/2025 Removed 8/5/2025 drug use Brian Hafley
0017 /2025 9/9/2025 9/1/2025 Brian Hafley
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0020 /2025 9/19/2025 9/1/2025 9/1/2025 Brian Hafley
0021 /2025 9/22/2025 Removed 6/15/2025 drug use Brian Hafley
0022 /2025 9/22/2025 9/1/2025 Brian Hafley
0023 /2025 9/22/2025 9/1/2025 Brian Hafley
0024 /2025 10/16/2025 8/14/2025 Brian Hafley
NGU Participant Tracking
Step-Up House Tracking 2025

Never Give Up Transitional Living

Dialectical Behavior Therapy Programming Guide

Dialectical Behavior Therapy (DBT) is a structured therapy that focuses on teaching four core skills—mindfulness, acceptance and distress tolerance, emotional regulation, and interpersonal effectiveness—to help you create a good life for yourself. Overall, DBT incorporates various skills to help individuals manage emotions and improve interpersonal relationships.

DBT is a type of Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (CBT). CBT focuses on helping people change unhelpful thought patterns. DBT takes those CBT ideas or challenging unhelpful thought patterns, but also adds additional elements like mindfulness, acceptance and distress tolerance, and interpersonal skills to give you more tools for dealing with hard situations.

Mindfulness Exercises

1. STOP Skill
2. Wise Mind
3. Mental Noting

Distress Tolerance Exercises

1. Cost Benefit Analysis
2. Willingness vs. Willfulness
3. Radical Acceptance

Emotion Regulation Exercises

1. Recognize Your Emotions
2. Check the Facts
3. Balancing Emotional Urges

Interpersonal Effectiveness Exercises

1. Communication Styles
2. DEARMAN
3. Barriers to Interpersonal Effectiveness

Never Give Up Transitional Living
Dialectical Behavior Therapy Programming Guide
DEARMAN

1. Introduction

In life, especially during the transition from incarceration to reentry, there are many times when we need to advocate for ourselves and communicate our needs clearly and respectfully. Sometimes we may feel like others won't understand our needs, or we fear being judged or rejected. In those moments, using DBT's DEARMAN skill can help us express our needs while maintaining our self-respect and the respect of others. This skill is especially useful for difficult conversations, whether with family, coworkers, or service providers.

DEARMAN is a structured way of communicating assertively, focusing on the importance of setting boundaries and making requests in an effective manner.

2. Steps for DEARMAN

Step One: Describe
Describe the situation in a clear and neutral way. Don't include judgments or exaggerations.

Example: "I've been working at the warehouse for a few weeks now, and I noticed that I am being asked to take on more tasks that I can manage within my shift."

Step Two: Express
Express your feelings and thoughts about the situation. Be honest and use "I" statements to avoid blaming others.

Example: "I feel overwhelmed when I'm given too many tasks at once. It's stressing me out and I'm worried about not being able to complete everything properly."

Step Three: Assert
Clearly state your needs or what you want from the other person. Be direct and assertive.

Example: "I need to have a manageable workload, or I will not be able to meet the expectations for quality work."

Step Four: Reinforce
Explain how your request will benefit the other person or the situation. This helps the person understand why it's in their interest to cooperate with your request.

Our Purpose

The Reentry Challenge

Each year, about 2,000 people are released from Nebraska state prisons. But reentering society isn't easy. Returning citizens face overlapping barriers—housing instability, employment discrimination, addiction, untreated mental health concerns, stigma, criminal thinking, and fractured family ties. Without meaningful support, many return to the system they just left.

The NGU Solution

The Never Give Up (NGU) Transitional Living Program is a sober, structured reentry program operated by the nonprofit Good Turn Labor. We help formerly incarcerated individuals move toward independent living with support, stability, and accountability.

Who We Serve

NGU supports men returning from prison who:

1. Are approved for community supervision or parole
2. Are motivated to participate in a structured, sober reentry program
3. Have completed the application, phone interview, and background review*

Individuals with a history of sex offense convictions are not eligible for the program

Meet The Team



Shane Reilly, MS
Program Director & Development Director



Julie Micek, LIMHP
Executive Director & Health Support and Counseling Specialist



Jimmy King
Assistant Program Director & Resident Manager



Brian Hafley
Case Manager

+ Peer Support Specialists

Get in Touch

- www.nevergiveupomaha.org
- ngutlomaha@gmail.com
- (402) 359 7404
- Omaha, Nebraska

Never Give Up

Never Give Up
Transitional Living



Testimonials

""Be ready for a life changing experience. This program its very motivating. It's very uplifting...What you put into this program is what you're gonna get out of it. There's great qualities in the program that enabled me to become self-sufficient, maintain good employment, work on my credit, and just become an all-around productive member of society and a good person."

-Jason G., Never Give Up Program Participant

"I've had the opportunity to work with numerous transitional living programs...NGU stands out as a model of excellence. Shane's commitment to structured support, accountability, and genuine care creates real opportunities for lasting change."

-Brian Bencker, Assistant Program Director of NDCS Community Supervision Service

"It is great to see [the men] come in and start their financial journey with us...Some of them have been able to do things they hadn't done before such as purchase a car from a dealership or...a home. It is the confidence that comes from being able to accomplish goals in a way they maybe hadn't before that makes this partnership special to all of us!"

-Yvonne, Financial Sales Manager, Centris Bank

HELP US CHANGE LIVES

Donate to Never Give Up through the 501(c)(3) organization, Good Turn Labor, LLC.

Our Services

Housing & Basic Needs
Stable housing and essentials—food, clothing, transport, and a phone—so participants can rebuild, not just survive.

Intensive Outpatient Programming (IOP)
Structured in-house groups for relapse prevention, coping, and recovery.

Dialectical Behavior Therapy
Evidence-based treatment for managing emotions, stress, and relationships.

Individual Counseling
Private counseling for trauma, mental health, addiction, and growth.

Alcoholics & Narcotics Anonymous
Peer-led 12-step groups providing support, accountability, and a sober community.

Employment Support
Job search assistance, skill building, and maintaining work.

Community & Family
Prosocial outings and family visits to rebuild trust and strengthen social bonds.

Financial Literacy Classes
Guidance in budgeting, saving, credit management, and financial stability.

ID & Benefits Assistance
Help securing ID, SSN, EBT, and Medicaid.

Faith-Based Support
Church attendance, mentorship, and faith-based volunteering.

NGU
TRANSITIONAL LIVING
"NEVER GIVE UP"

Our Goal

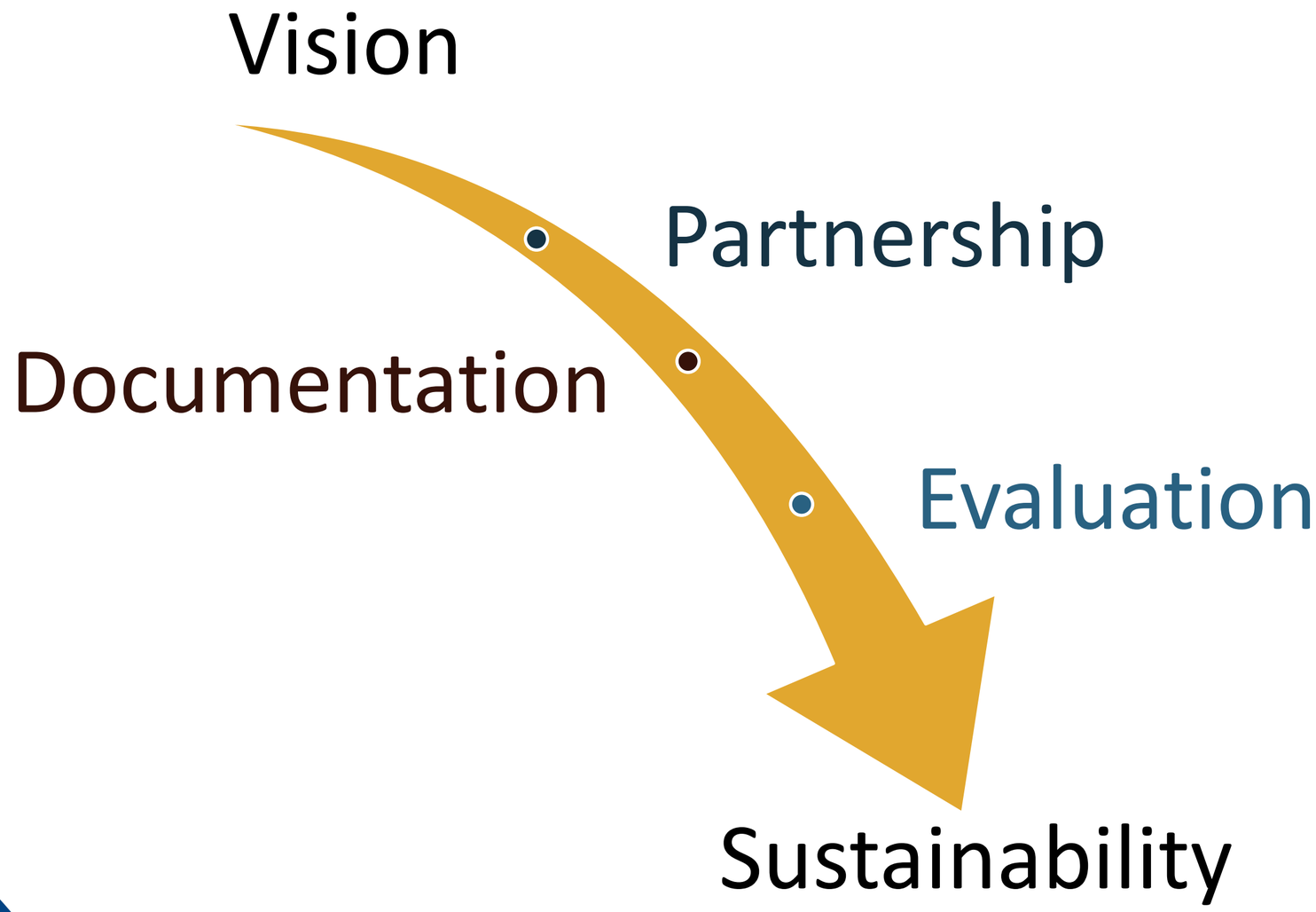
To reduce recidivism and support long lasting integration by building personal accountability, strengthening community connections, and ensuring access to the tools people need to succeed.

Why We're Unique

- **Lived Experience:** Every man on our team beat prison—and now leads others to freedom
- **Unshakeable Belief:** We never give up on you
- **Real Support, Real Change:** More than a place to stay, NGU helps rebuild lives
- **Creative Solutions:** Fresh ideas for lasting change



BUILDING THE FOUNDATION



THE ROAD AHEAD – MEASURING IMPACT

- **Process Evaluation** – understanding how NGU works

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- **Process Evaluation** – understanding how NGU works

- **Outcome Evaluation** – measuring results & long-term impact

THE ROAD AHEAD – MEASURING IMPACT

- **Process Evaluation** – understanding how NGU works
- **Outcome Evaluation** – measuring results & long-term impact
- **Scaling What Works** – sharing the model nationally

BUILDING THE BLUEPRINT FOR SECOND CHANCES

- **Never Give Up** isn't just a name – it's a ***philosophy***

- Together, our goal is to prove that second chances can be both compassionate and evidence-based

- Together, we can help keep men out of prison.

THANK YOU!

Questions?

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tgonzales@unomaha.edu

Support NGU at
www.nevergiveupomaha.org